



plans in that regard. "We are preparing strategic bids for both the 2029 and 2031 [World Athletics Championships] editions. Since the hosting rights will be awarded together, we are open to securing either one."

Neeraj's idea of India's athletic future, though, isn't limited to just top-tier meets. He envisions more stadiums and a wider spread of elite coaches across the breadth of the country.

"I am from a village which didn't have a stadium. I used to go to Panipat for training. If there was a stadium nearby, maybe more children could have trained.

When I fly across Europe, I see some 50 stadiums every 10-15 minutes. In India, we will see as many stadiums if we travel from Kashmir to Kanyakumari. So, there should be as many stadiums as possible in India, with more specialised coaches training youngsters," said Neeraj.

For long, Neeraj has been the totem of Indian athletics, a glittering jewel of excellence for a success-starved nation.

With the NC Classic, he has established that he is capable of more, as he lights up yet another untrodden path for track and field sports in India.



Silver-lining: Kenya's Julius Yego, the 2015 world champion and Rio Olympic silver medallist, produced a season-best 84.51m on his fourth attempt to secure second place. K. MURALI KUMAR



Underwhelming return: Germany's Thomas Rohler, the Rio 2016 gold medallist, endured a disappointing outing, finishing 11th out of 12 with a throw of 75.85m. K. MURALI KUMAR